with deliberate and malicious intent. Under this provision, serious scholars like Wendy Doniger, who has authored several learned and brilliant studies of Hinduism, have been sued, and publishers, intimidated by the forces arrayed against them and reluctant to spend what it would take to defend their authors' freedoms, have usually caved in. One of Doniger's books on Hinduism was not only withdrawn from the marketplace by its publishers, but all existing copies pulped in order not to give offence to the Hindutva lobby.

The destruction and pulping of books, and the burning of libraries, is possible because the colonial-era law criminalises even accurate statements about Indian religion and history if these offend the sentiments of any community in India. Still, to see such actions being carried out in the name of the Hindu faith is profoundly disquieting. In the Hindu culture that I grew up with, books are revered. If I so much as accidentally touched a fallen book or even a magazine or newspaper with my foot, I was brought up to bend down, touch it again with my fingertips in apology and apply my fingers to my eyes and forehead to beg forgiveness from the Goddess Saraswati for my transgression, a practice I still perform in my seventh decade. This respect for the printed word can be found among Hindus of every part of the country. How can people who claim to be Hindu not just disrespect but actually destroy books?

The destruction of some people's books is inevitably accompanied by the promotion of other books. Foreign Minister Sushma Swaraj, not known to be an RSS sympathiser but aggressive in her cultural nationalism, proposed the adoption of the Bhagavad Gita as the 'Rashtriya Granth', or national holy book. There are four problems with Sushma Swaraj's advocacy of the Bhagavad Gita as our 'national holy book', of which the first is that, to cite no less a source than Prime Minister Modi himself, we already have a national holy book: it's called the Constitution of India.

The second is that we are a land of multiple faiths, each of which has its own holy books; on what basis would we pick any one of them in the capacity of a national holy book? Which Sikh would put the Gita ahead of the Guru Granth Sahib, for instance?